

Week 4 — Tongue Diagnosis

EAM310 · EAST ASIAN MEDICINE DIAGNOSIS I · VUIM SUMMER 2026

△ Quiz 3 — July 31, 2026

Class: Friday August 1, 2026 · 9AM–1PM

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REQUIRED READINGS — DUE BEFORE AUGUST 1

FCM CHAPTER 23 — MACIOCIA

- Clinical significance of tongue diagnosis
- Tongue body: color, shape, movement
- Tongue coating: color, thickness, moisture
- Topography — organ zone mapping
- Three layers: Wei, Ying, Yuan

ANN CECIL-STERMAN — TONGUE DX BOOK

- Recommended by Prof. Schrier for Week 4
- Clinical photographs of tongue findings
- Pattern correlations with tongue evidence
- Practical observation guidelines
- Integration with pulse and pattern diagnosis

WEEK 4 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Identify clinical significance of tongue diagnosis
- Describe the three tongue layers (Wei/Ying/Yuan)
- Map organ zones on the tongue (3 Burner topography)
- Recognize peeling, geographic, and mirror tongue
- Interpret tongue body color (pale, red, purple, blue)
- Interpret tongue coating (color, thickness, moisture)
- Identify tongue body shape findings and their patterns
- Apply tongue diagnosis to clinical case examples

ASSESSMENT CALENDAR

Date	Event	Material Covered
Jul 31	△ Quiz 3	Week 3 material — Pulse Diagnosis, 28 Qualities, Seasonal Pulses
Aug 1	Week 4 Class	Tongue Diagnosis — body color, shape, coating, topography
Aug 7	MIDTERM + Journal 1–25	Weeks 1–4 comprehensive
Aug 21	Quiz 4	Week 4+ material
Sep 11	FINAL + Journal 26–50	Weeks 6–9 comprehensive

IN-CLASS PRACTICE — WHAT TO EXPECT

TONGUE OBSERVATION LAB

Week 4 includes partner tongue observation practice. Come ready to:

- Observe partner's tongue under natural light — tip to root, body then coat
- Record body color, shape, coat color, coat thickness, moisture in your journal
- Practice identifying at least one zone finding and correlating to organ
- Document findings (Journal entry counts toward midterm — entries 1–25 due Aug 7)

THREE LAYERS 三層		
Judge	anti-pathogenic Qi	Exuberance or decline of Zheng Qi
Distinguish	thermal nature	Heat vs Cold; Full vs Empty
Detect	disease location	Organ zone tells you WHERE
Predict	disease course	Tongue changes as disease progresses
Key Rule: The tongue body color always shows the true condition — even when other signs are misleading (False Heat/Cold)		

Zone	Organ(s)	Key Finding
Tip	Heart 心	Red tip = Heart-Fire; depressed tip = Heart constraint
Just behind tip	Lung 肺	Swollen front = Phlegm in Lungs
Sides	Liver / Gallbladder 肝膽	Red sides = LV-Fire; reddish-purple sides = LV Blood stasis
Center oval	Spleen / Stomach 脾胃	Central crack = ST-Yin def; swollen center = Phlegm-Damp in MJ
Root / Back	KD · BL · Intestines	Rootless coat = KD-Yin def; thick root coat = Damp-Heat in LJ
Contralateral rule: Left tongue side = Right breast; Right tongue side = Left breast (breast cancer screening in CM)		

3-BURNER DIVISION (KIRSCHBAUM 2000)

Anterior 1/3	Upper Jiao — Heart / Lung
Middle 1/3	Middle Jiao — Spleen / Stomach / LV / GB
Posterior 1/3	Lower Jiao — Kidney / Bladder / SI / LI

OBSERVATION CONDITIONS

Lighting	Natural light only — fluorescent distorts color
Sequence	Tip → middle → root, 5–15 sec max
Diet/Meds	Nothing coloring 30 min before
Season	Tongue shifts seasonally — factor in borderline findings
Age	Children: redder normal; Elderly: drier, paler, contracted = normal

TONGUE BODY FINDINGS

1. Body Color	Blood · Nutritive Qi · Yin organs · Heat/Cold · Yin/Yang def
2. Body Shape	Blood · Nutritive Qi · Excess vs Deficiency
3. Coating	Yang organs · pathogenic factors · Heat/Cold · Excess/Def
4. Moisture	State of Body Fluids

Color	Indicates	Key Clinical Details (from slides)
Pale Red	Normal	Slightly moist · thin white coat · not swollen or thin · sublingual veins not distended
Pale	Qi/Blood def · Yang def	Slightly pale = Qi def · Pale + dry = Blood def · Pale on sides = LV Blood def · Pale + wet = Yang def · Pale + swollen center + teethmarks = SP-Qi def
Red	Heat (Full or Empty)	Red + coating = Full-Heat · Red without coating = Empty-Heat · Red tip = Heart-Fire (w/ coat) or HT Empty-Heat (w/o coat) · Red sides + coat = LV-Fire or GB Full-Heat · Red sides w/o coat = LV Yin def + Empty-Heat · Red center = ST Heat or ST Empty-Heat
Purple	Blood stasis	Always Blood stasis · Reddish-purple = stasis from Heat · Bluish-purple = stasis from Cold · Reddish-purple sides = LV Blood stasis + Heat · Bluish-purple sides (women) = Blood stasis in Uterus from Cold · Purple center = Blood stasis in Stomach
Blue/Bluish	Interior Cold · Blood stasis	Extreme interior Cold with Blood stasis; Yang Qi unable to warm and move Blood

⚠ **Red Points:** Red tip = Heart; Red sides = LV/GB; Red center = ST; Red front third = Lung. Always note the zone of red points — location tells you the organ.

Shape Finding	Clinical Indication	Zone Note
SWOLLEN / ENLARGED		
Swollen (overall)	Dampness or Phlegm; SP Yang def with water retention; Heat in Blood + Dampness	With pale body = Damp-Cold; with red body = Damp-Heat
Swollen sides (red)	LV/GB Damp-Heat or Fire	Liver area = sides
Swollen tip (red)	Heart-Fire blazing	Heart area = tip
Swollen front third	Lung-Qi def or Phlegm in Lungs	Lung area = front 1/3
Swollen center (pale)	SP-Qi def · teethmarks often present	SP/ST = center oval
THIN / CONTRACTED		
Thin, dry	Blood deficiency; Yin deficiency with Empty-Heat drying fluids	
Thin, wet/moist	Yang deficiency; Cold pattern	
MARKS / TEXTURE		
Teethmarks	SP-Qi def (with swollen body) or Dampness	Often with pale, swollen tongue
Cracked / Fissured	Yin def · Excess Heat consuming fluids · normal variation if lifelong	Central crack = ST; multiple = KD Yin def
Centerline crack	Heat in Stomach; injury to Stomach fluids	Reaches tip = HT; stops in middle = ST
Red points/petechia	Heat or Fire in corresponding zone organ	Tip=HT · Front=LU · Sides=LV · Center=ST
MOVEMENT		
Deviated	Internal Wind; Liver Wind (check trauma first)	Miley Cyrus = yellow coat+deviated → check for trauma
Quivering	SP-Qi def; Blood def	
Moving/Restless	Liver Wind; Internal Wind	
Stiff	Internal Wind; Heat consuming fluids; Phlegm misting Heart	
Flaccid / Limp	Severe Blood or fluid def; extreme Yin def	
Long	Heat in Heart; Heat in Stomach	
Short	Phlegm + Damp in Interior; severe Cold contracting; extreme Blood def	

Color	Indicates	Moisture	Indicates
Thin White	Normal; mild/early exterior; Wind-Cold	Slightly moist	Normal — Body Fluids intact
Thick White	Interior Cold; Damp-Cold; food stagnation	Too wet / Glossy	Yang def; Damp or Phlegm; water accumulation
White Sticky/Greasy	Dampness or Phlegm-Cold	Too dry	Heat; Yin def; Body Fluid damage
Thin Yellow	Exterior Wind-Heat; early Heat	Sticky / Slippery	Dampness and/or Phlegm
Thick Yellow	Full-Heat; food stagnation with Heat	Rough / Sandpaper	Severe injury to Body Fluids; extreme Heat
Yellow Sticky/Greasy	Damp-Heat or Phlegm-Heat		
Gray (glossy)	Cold pattern: Damp or Damp-Phlegm	Type	Description & Meaning
Gray (dry)	Heat pattern: Yin deficiency or extreme Heat	Partially peeled	ST Yin and Qi def — some coat remains
Black (wet)	Extreme Cold; Yang def; Damp-Phlegm	Geographic	Scattered areas peeled with raised borders — ST Yin/Qi def
Black (dry)	Extreme Heat; Yin exhaustion	Mirror (total)	No coat, smooth shiny — ST Yin exhausted; severe Yin def
		Dappled	Missing patches but new coat growing — transitional state
No coat (peeled)	ST Yin def; Stomach fails to produce coat	Coating diagnostic logic: Coat = Yang organs + pathogens. Absence = ST Yin def (can't produce coat). Rootless coat (no attachment, floats) = ST/KD Qi def.	
Thin coat	Normal; mild pathogen; early stage		
Thick coat	Pathogenic factor present; stronger = thicker		
Total absence (red)	ST + KD Yin def with Empty-Heat		

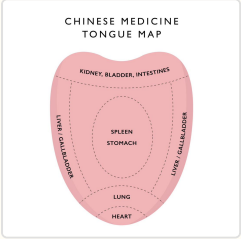
Tongue Finding	Pattern / Interpretation
Slightly pale, dry	Blood Deficiency
Pale, wet, swollen	Yang Deficiency / Damp-Cold
Pale sides	Liver Blood Deficiency
Pale, swollen center, teethmarks	Spleen Qi Deficiency
Red, yellow coat	Full-Heat (Excess Yang)
Red, no coat (peeled)	Empty-Heat (Yin Deficiency)
Red tip only	Heart-Fire (w/ coat) or HT Empty-Heat (w/o coat)
Red sides, coat	Liver-Fire or GB Full-Heat
Red sides, no coat	Liver Yin Deficiency with Empty-Heat
Purple, reddish	Blood Stasis from Heat
Purple, bluish	Blood Stasis from Cold
Centerline crack (reaches tip)	Heart Heat/Fire; injury to HT fluids
Centerline crack (stops in middle)	Stomach Yin/fluid deficiency
Rootless coat	Stomach Qi or Yin Deficiency
No coat at all, red body	Kidney Yin Deficiency with Empty-Heat
No coat in front third	Lung Yin Deficiency
No coat in center only	Stomach Yin Deficiency
Deviated tongue	Interior/Liver Wind (check trauma first)
Dark distended sublingual veins	Blood Stagnation
Pink body, red HT/LV sides	Heat in Liver and Heart
Purple-red body + swollen center	Blood Stagnation + Heat + Phlegm-Damp in MJ
Dry yellow coat in Middle/Lower Burner	Heat in ST and/or KD

PATTERN NAME	DISEASE CATEGORY	WEEK / QUIZ

ETIOLOGY	ORGAN SYSTEM	DATE

CLINICAL ESSENTIALS · TONGUE · PULSE · TREATMENT PRINCIPLE

CHINESE MEDICINE
TONGUE MAP



Wrist	CUN 寸	GUAN 關	CHI 尺
L HT/PC		LV/GB	KD-Yin
R LU/LI		SP/ST	KD-Yang

COLOR / COAT / SHAPE

QUALITY / OVERALL

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